

FIONA MIETCHEN PAINTER EDITED

Travel Radio Australia and we're in London at the World Travel Market and travelled all the way from Australia is Fiona Meacham Painter who's the general manager of Bill Peach Journeys. Now Bill Peach is a household name in Australia. Fiona, welcome to the program.

Lovely to be here, thank you. And tell us a bit about a bit about the background of of this company at BillPeachJourneys.com.au. Now Bill Peach was a former investigative journalist and and he decided to start a travel company and tours. Tell us all about it.

That's right, he surely did. So you're quite right, he is a bit of a household name even today, even though he in the 60s it was that he was on TV on a regular basis in people's evenings, Lifetime series and whatnot but mostly initially as an investigative journalist as you said and then he decided to branch out from doing his evening TV show and he began doing travel documentaries and it was during these travel documentaries that his love of this beautiful big brown land came to the fore and he brought people to the outback and beyond in such a way that had never been done before. He was using at that time a private aircraft to fly himself and his videographer and photographer around.

When he got home people said we loved watching what we saw on the television but we want to come with you next time go and get some aircraft and that's how the entire company was born. So over 40 years ago and since then we have taken lots of very lucky people to very very far-flung and very remote places that sometimes are only accessible by private aircraft but done in a absolutely stylish and luxurious way. People are never the same really after they've done one of our tours.

Tell us about some of the destinations that you go to it sounds very very glamorous. Well look it is glamorous however for example I was just having a chat with somebody and we were talking about Coober Pedy. They didn't really know the story behind Coober Pedy and that it can get so hot there that the very very clever and industrious people that live there decided well this is a bit silly living above ground when it's this hot so they decided to basically create an entire community underground and it's much cooler down there.

It's also of course a very famous opal mining town. We take people there and we fly in we we visit all sorts of incredible remarkable creations if that's the right word. For example there's a incredible church that's been borrowed out of the side of a hill and you can see off in the distance through beautiful stained glass windows and it's unlike any other church of course in the world because it's buried into the ground.

There is people there that have lived underground for very many years and we give clients the option if they're feeling like it if they want to that they can also stay in a hotel that's underground. From Coober Pedy we go on to wonderful destinations over in the Margaret River for example

and we visit the very top of the top when we talk about Sandalford winery which is just in the Swan Valley. Wherever it is that we go however while we're going to take you to an immersive experience you're going to learn about the place at a very very deep impressive level but while doing so it's all going to be at the very best luxury that it's possible.

So you're going to be very well fed very well watered and the most important is that it is an all-inclusive package so once you're on board you're looked after by the expert journey director that accompanies you so all accommodation all touring all transfers all meals are included along with wine and soft drinks as well. It looks fantastic just looking on your website here I can see a bunch of people having a beautiful dinner right outside Uluru looking at Uluru in the desert with white tablecloths it looks absolutely superb tell us about that experience. Yes so you're absolutely right it's nothing quite like being at Uluru people have a really incredible experience when they go there we see it from all different angles we do an incredible tour called the Red Centre so we do an aerial sightseeing where you're flying over Uluru and Kata Tjuta and many other amazing places where we go out to Kings Creek Station but at the very same time we enjoy Uluru in a morning tour so very very early because the colours of the morning can be different from the colours of the evening but we also enjoy it in a way that is incredibly remarkable by having a look at that remarkable red dirt there's really nothing like the red dirt that exists out in this part of desert and what they do is they manage to set up amazing it's really a three-star five-star experience where you're having a three-course dinner and you're sitting in the view of Uluru in the distance but at the same time you're having an incredible meal and you're being served wonderful wine from the region that'll be somewhere in Australia and of course candlelight dinner white tablecloths as you said and there's really nothing else like it people people remember this experience forever just looking at this photo is giving me goosebumps just looking at the photo I mean imagine being there looking at Uluru looking at the the sunset there you've got a picture there and so beautiful and I suppose you've been out there with the stars too the stars must be a billion stars in the sky well there's nothing like the stars is what you see out there and the beautiful thing about this experience is that there is a stargazer that will explain the entire Milky Way to you so as I say you're not just having a look at incredible scenery and doing the Instagram shot or anything like that you're having a very immersive experience so you're learning about the culture you're learning about the people the pioneers that forged the way out there and it really is a wonderful experience.

We're chatting with Fiona Meacham Painter who's the general manager of buildpeachjourneys.com.au based in Sydney and tell us about a couple of more of your favorite places that you take people to Fiona. Yeah well we have another tour that's actually called the Gulf to Gulf air tour now the reason it's interesting is because it doesn't go to places that many people have been to and I think that's its charm so we had two departures this year which were completely sold out and we had two departures last year that were also completely sold out so people are absolutely loving this tour it's remarkable in that it begins in Adelaide but as you can see it heads up through Inaminka and we're visiting very very significant places to Australian

history including the Burke and Wills dig tree so we all know who Burke and Wills are they're incredible Australian explorers from there we head to the wonderful Birdsville it's the Birdsville hotel and we're lucky enough to go out and see really some of the most wonderful views you're ever going to see from a place called Red Hill then we're heading up to Mount Isa and the wonderful mining town that we all know about then we're back up to Burke town which is really unlike anywhere else on earth just has to be seen to be believed a place that very not very many people have gone is our top point on this tour called Groot Island so of course they do some manganese mining and whatnot up there but there's also a lot of cultural significance more than that it's just spectacularly beautiful it's untouched it's pristine and we stay in a remarkable property that has the view of it's too it's too incredible to talk about actually from there we head down to Tennant Cree and then we head back through Uluru where once again you get to see all the wonders of Uluru that are there then that one heads back through Kipapiti and then finally the Flinders Ranges where we stop at a place called Rawnsley Park and it's a remarkable property in the Flinders Ranges where you're the level of comfort is not what anybody would expect you really are looked after incredibly well hardwood floors and all of the trappings that you would want from a luxury property however at the same time you're looking out at what can only be described as a nature's wonder of the Flinders Ranges yeah it sounds magnificent and what's your background uh just before we go Fiona were you involved in travel yourself before you got involved with buildpeachjourneys.com.au yes absolutely i've been a devotee of travel ever since my parents took on our first european trip when i was five i think from that point onwards it was it was around the world trip i got the bug very very early and i knew instantly that i had to be in this business and so i started off as a journey director on the trans-siberian railway so it was all amazing places like russia and china and mongolia kazakhstan thereafter and then once i joined buildpeachjourneys.com.au i really discovered the magnificence of australia and it was exploring this country else also as a journey director but i've also been the reservations manager and the marketing manager and different different parts of the business but it's been an incredible experience to really see this country from not just the air but from within and to really discover the most magnificent place that exists on earth and we're very lucky that we call it home local people to to really really get get involved with you and and have some magnificent journeys with buildpeachjourneys.com.au and fiona mitchen painter thank you so much for being on the program oh thank you very much for your time bye